billion. After the communication to the London Stock Exchange, the Corus board recommended Tata Steel's offer to their shareholders. It was eager to hive off its assets and found the bid to be financially appealing. It was the only one that they had received so far. Leng told an Indian newspaper, 'This combination with Tata, for Corus shareholders and employees alike, represents the right partner at the right time at the right place and on the right terms.' Speaking to me some thirteen years later, he airs the same sentiments: 'If you wanted to have an owner, price to one side, if you looked at the pedigree, the person, the culture, the values, if you looked at that, it [Tata Steel] was five star, if you can rate such a thing.' In less than a fortnight after the communication to the stock exchange, Corus announced that an extraordinary general meeting (EGM) was to be held on 4 December for shareholders to consider the proposal of Tata Steel.

The Battle over Corus

As Ratan was focused on working on how to maximize the benefits of the acquisition, he was suddenly challenged by CSN. About a month after the group sent its proposal, Corus received a bid from CSN. It was for 475 pence per share, higher than the Tata offer by 20 pence. CSN had valued the Anglo-Dutch steel company at roughly $8.8 billion.

Corus adjourned the proposed EGM to 20 December to consider the counteroffer. The decision was taken to give time to CSN to complete due diligence and 'determine whether it will put forward a formal offer'. A bidding war was looming on the horizon. It was clear that both the contending groups would be bidding on the strength of borrowed cash. But the distinct advantage, according to *The Independent*, that Tata Steel had over CSN, was that it had the backing of a larger group. 'Tata was more international than CSN,' comments Leng.

The same *The Independent* article goes on to say that both the bids were 'grounded in the same industrial logic of marrying the fast growing markets and cheap sources of commodity steel of the developing world with the finished, higher value stuff that services the developed West'. Yet they differed in one aspect. Tata taking on Corus would open the market for the higher growth region of Asia. In comparison, CSN would give Corus 'immediate access to cheap sources of iron ore and plate steel'. Commenting on the supply of ore, Otavio de Garcia Lazcano, CSN's